

Spill containment for Data Center Fuel Systems | Consolidated Containment

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According to CBS News New York, thousands of gallons of diesel spilled from an Equinix data center in Secaucus, New Jersey, into Anderson Creek, a tributary of the Hackensack River. The New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection reported that the spill was contained, and cleanup crews were working to remove fuel from the impacted area. The incident is a clear reminder that data centers are not just digital infrastructure. They are also industrial facilities with fuel systems, generators, storage tanks, pumps, transfer equipment, and environmental responsibilities. When diesel is stored, transferred, or used on site, secondary containment should be part of the plan from the beginning. Data Centers Depend on Backup Power Data centers are built around uptime. When power is interrupted, backup systems are expected to keep servers, cooling systems, and critical operations running. That often means diesel generators and on-site fuel storage. These systems are necessary for continuity, but they also introduce spill risk. Fuel tanks can leak. Transfer systems can fail. Pumps, hoses, fittings, valves, and automated systems can malfunction. Even a small issue can become a larger environmental problem if fuel reaches soil, storm drains, retention areas, or nearby waterways. For facilities designed to protect digital infrastructure, physical infrastructure protection matters too. Fuel Storage Requires More Than a Tank A fuel tank alone is not a containment plan. Proper spill containment considers what happens if fuel leaves the tank, generator, pump, or transfer point. Where will it go? What surface will it reach? Is there a drain nearby? Could it move beyond the equipment area before anyone notices? These questions are especially important for data centers because many backup fuel systems are located outdoors, near buildings, loading areas, mechanical yards, or stormwater pathways. Secondary containment helps create a controlled area around potential spill sources. That can include containment berms, liners, custom containment areas, and other solutions designed to help keep fuel from spreading beyond the equipment footprint. Key Areas That May Need Secondary Containment For data centers and other critical infrastructure sites, containment planning may apply to several areas, including: - Diesel generators - Bulk fuel storage tanks - Day tanks - Fuel transfer points - Pumps and hoses - Temporary fueling areas - Mobile equipment - Maintenance or service zones - Chemical totes, drums, or other stored liquids Every facility layout is different. Some sites may need a standard containment berm around a specific piece of equipment. Others may require custom-sized containment for larger tanks, multiple generators, or unusual equipment layouts. The goal is the same: help control a spill before it reaches soil, drains, or waterways. Why Secondary Containment Matters for Data Centers Secondary containment is not about

responding to a spill, it's about reducing the risk before a spill happens. For data centers, containment can support: Environmental protection: Diesel spills can impact soil, stormwater systems, creeks, wetlands, and surrounding property. Containment helps reduce the chance of fuel spreading beyond the equipment area. Operational control: When a spill is contained, crews have a better opportunity to respond, recover material, and limit downtime or disruption. Infrastructure protection: Fuel can affect more than the environment. It can create cleanup challenges around buildings, equipment pads, concrete surfaces, and critical facility areas. Compliance planning: Facilities that store fuel or other regulated liquids often need to account for spill prevention, control, and containment. A clear containment plan helps support responsible site operations. Long-term risk reduction: As data centers expand, backup power systems are expanding with them. Containment should be considered during design, construction, expansion, and maintenance planning. Standard vs. Custom Containment Not every site needs the same solution. Standard containment berms can be a good fit for generators, pumps, totes, drums, and equipment with common footprints. These options can help facilities address containment needs quickly and efficiently. Custom containment may make more sense when a site has larger equipment, multiple tanks, limited space, unusual dimensions, or specific access requirements. Custom berms and liners can be built around the actual equipment layout instead of forcing the site to work around a standard size. For data centers, this flexibility matters. Backup systems are often placed where space, access, drainage, and building layout all have to be considered. Containment Should Be Planned Before the Spill The New Jersey incident shows how quickly a fuel system issue can move from a facility problem to an environmental concern. Once diesel reaches a creek, storm drain, or surrounding area, cleanup becomes more complicated, more visible, and more costly. Secondary containment cannot prevent every equipment failure, but it can help limit how far a spill travels when something goes wrong. For data centers, fuel containment should be treated as part of critical infrastructure planning. Not after construction. Not after an inspection. Not after a spill. From the beginning. Secondary Containment for Critical Infrastructure Consolidated Containment manufactures standard and custom secondary containment solutions for industrial facilities, fuel storage areas, generators, and critical infrastructure sites. Our containment berms and liners are designed to help protect equipment areas, support spill control planning, and provide practical containment options for a wide range of site layouts. As data center construction and expansion continue, containment planning should grow with it. If your facility stores diesel, operates backup generators, or manages fuel transfer on site, secondary containment should be part of the conversation.